

Unsafe Building January 8, 2026

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ft4nZW6Eu9A
Publication Date	2026-01-09T23:51:28Z
Target Category	muncie_city

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Comprehensive Municipal Meeting Summary

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

(Note: The meeting opened directly with a statutory enforcement proceeding functioning as the primary session, documented below under Section 2 and Section 4.)

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** 00:00:19 Presiding officers and staff convened the Unsafe Building Hearing Authority meeting. The unsafe building law (IC 36-7-9) was formally entered into the record.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Hearing Authority Members Present:** Gretchen Cheeseman, Mayor Dan Ridenour, James Heimlick, and Councilman Jeff Green. (Note: John Lee was noted as potentially running behind).
 - **City Staff Present:** Hannah Collins, Caressa Sanders, Danny Han, Richard Rawlings, Melinda Coffee (arriving after an inspection), and City Attorneys Aubrey Christ and John Mohaman.
 - **Recording Secretary:** Courtney Walker.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** 00:02:37 All participants and attendees standing for the hearing were sworn in collectively under oath.
 - **Approval of Minutes:** *(Not explicitly detailed in the transcript).*
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:03:18 Unsafe Building Case: 406-408 East Jackson Street**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** City Staff / Enforcement Authority.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The board discussed the property, noting it is a historic multifront structure dating to the 1870s (Italianate style) that has fallen into severe deterioration under out-of-state ownership (Wyoming).
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** 00:03:44 Kevin Clinger (neighbor at 400 E. Jackson St.) testified about the historical significance and architectural value of the building, urging the city to save it rather than demolish it.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to affirm the demolition order, assess a \$5,000 civil penalty (due to multi-family status), and continue the matter.
- **00:05:45 Unsafe Building Case: 3907 East Jackson Street (Mobile Home Park)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** City Staff / Enforcement Authority & War Recre (representing owner Alex Recre / ANREC Mobile Home Park).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The park contains 18 lots, with 11 vacant mobile homes in severe disrepair. The representative noted recent work on the park garage and stated an intent to board up units while seeking an Indiana installer's license. The board expressed frustration over years of neglect. Individual trailer numbers were categorized for demolition, repair, trash removal, and vacation orders.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:**
 - 00:05:55 Christy Kirkland (neighbor) testified about the severe state of abandonment and safety issues.
 - 00:15:05 Barbara Bickford (neighboring property owner at 3801<U+2013>3811 E. Jackson St.) testified about vagrancy, severe structural failure (floors missing, fire hazards from squatters burning wood inside units), and multi-year neglect.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to affirm separate orders (rehab/repair orders for specific units with a 30-day continuance and required inspections; demolition and vacate orders for dilapidated units 3, 5, 7, 11, 12, 15, and 16).
- **00:30:31 Unsafe Building Case: 1729 South Walnut Street**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Christy Brown (representing mortgage holder Wells Fargo).

- **Deliberation Summary:** The property suffered fire damage and is currently in foreclosure, with a sheriff's sale scheduled for February 11, 2026. The mortgage company secured and boarded up the property.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to affirm the demolition order with no fines assessed, and continued to March 12, 2026, pending the sheriff's sale outcome.
- **00:34:50 Unsafe Building Cases: Middletown Property Group Properties (Cases 5 through 9)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Colin Asbury (Middletown Property Group).
 - **Deliberation Summary:**
 - **00:35:03 824 West Wayne Street:** Approved by Voice Vote to affirm the rehab order and continue for 30 days.
 - **00:36:08 523 West 8th Street (Garage):** Approved by Voice Vote to continue the garage rehab order for 30 days.
 - **00:37:22 2017 North Glenwood:** Released by Voice Vote pending payment of a \$150 fine.
 - **00:38:12 1127 South Jefferson:** Extensive repairs underway; approved by Voice Vote for a 90-day continuance to April 9, 2026.
 - **00:39:29 2204 South Elm Street:** Approved by Voice Vote for a 30-day continuance.
- **00:40:19 Unsafe Building Case: 1924 West 17th Street**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Aaron Vance (Property Owner).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The property suffered fire damage. The owner reported insurance disputes and discussed a potential sale to JW Construction.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to continue for 30 days, requiring a formal sales contract and continued cleanup progress at the next hearing.
- **00:43:55 Unsafe Building Case: 1900 Block West 17th Street**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Aaron Vance.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Adjoining vacant lot connected to the 17th Street property. Board members advised the owner on legal aid resources for insurance issues and offered local coordination help for cleanup.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote for a 30-day continuance.
- **00:47:30 Unsafe Building Case: 3705 South Madison Street**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Phil Sharp (Topstar Realtor / Sharp Property Management).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Management reported cleanup of exterior trash and ongoing bids for roof and HVAC repairs. The board expressed strict dissatisfaction with out-of-town ownership (Washington) and lack of formal written plans.

- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to continue to February 12, 2026, with an explicit requirement for a written development/rehabilitation plan.
- **00:53:10 Unsafe Building Case: 824 West 15th Street**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Patrick (Property Representative).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Upstairs units are 90% renovated; downstairs tenants (vulnerable individuals) are being assisted while cleanup of severe contamination is finalized in coordination with the board of health.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to release the property contingent upon final health department inspection.
- **00:54:50 Unsafe Building Case: Cedarwood East Drive (Liberty Mobile Home Park)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Cara Davis (Property Manager).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Management reported that previous work orders addressing door locks, plumbing, and kitchen repairs were completed under a prior manager.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to release the property pending a satisfactory inspection.
- **00:59:25 Unsafe Building Case: 501 South Hawthorne Drive**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Sher Store (Property Owner).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Gutter repairs and exterior cleanup completed. The board warned the owner regarding outstanding property taxes eligible for tax sale.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to release the property.
- **01:01:28 Unsafe Building Case: 725 North Jefferson Street**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Cleave Gregory (Property Owner/Resident).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The resident-owner has been repairing the roof independently during weather permitting conditions. The board discussed potential eligibility for a city homeowner rehab program.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to continue to April 9, 2026.
- **01:04:17 Unsafe Building Cases: Renovation Properties (4611 & 4613 South Madison Street)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Joan Bird (representing Renovation / new owners who purchased in December).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** New ownership purchased the complex for \$1.1 million, immediately investing in heavy electrical, plumbing, roof flat-deck replacement, heat source restoration, and squatter/trash removal.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:**

- 4611 S. Madison St.: Approved by Voice Vote to release.
 - 4613 S. Madison St.: Approved by Voice Vote to release pending confirmation of a demolition permit for a removed garage structure.
 - **01:12:40 Unsafe Building Case: 801 West North Street**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Joseph Fleming (Maintenance representative for Cheryl Buys LLC).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The 9-unit converted apartment building requires severe reduction in unit count (down to 5) due to ceiling height and habitability violations. Vacate orders are pending through the health department.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote for a 30-day continuance requiring a budget, schedule, and timetable.
 - **01:20:05 Unsafe Building Case: 1724 South Poet Avenue**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Margarita Soraniano (Power of Attorney for Owner).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Exterior improvements noted; interior renovation ongoing under active permits.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to continue to May 14, 2026, assess a \$150 penalty for missing a prior inspection (with potential for waiver upon completion), and bypass separate hearing orders due to active building permits.
 - **01:23:48 Unsafe Building Case: 10001 East 29th Street (Auto Salvage/Lot)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Heather McKibben.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussion regarding vehicle removal quotas, scrap lists, state revenue tax disputes, and state operating license status.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to continue to February 12, 2026, ordering the removal of 40 additional vehicles with verifiable dated removal logs.
 - **01:31:52 Unsafe Building Case: 4305 West Burton Drive**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** James Merchant (Property Owner).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Exterior OSB sheathing installed; garage door openings and windows boarded up for winter.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to continue for 90 days to April 9, 2026, for final inspection.
 - **01:38:40 Bulk Docket Adoption (Default Cases):**
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Passed Unanimously by Voice Vote to adopt staff recommendations and findings for properties where no owners appeared after due notice (Docket Numbers: 1, 10, 12, 15, 16, 18, 19, 21, 23, 24, 26, 28, 32, 34, 36, and 39).
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5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

(Note: Public testimony and comment were integrated directly into individual property hearings rather than a separate general forum. See Section 4 for detailed citizen and neighbor testimonies regarding Jackson Street and Mobile Home Park properties).

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** 01:27:00 Future hearing dates established, specifically noting upcoming sessions on February 12, 2026, March 12, 2026, April 9, 2026, and May 14, 2026.
 - **Adjournment:** 01:41:13 The meeting concluded following the final docket approvals.
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